Social Science - Answer Sheet - Student 03

Question 1: Explain the differences between sociology, anthropology, and political science within the field of social science. Provide examples of research topics for each discipline.

Answer: Sociology examines how people interact within groups, focusing on social relationships, institutions, and patterns of behavior. Typical research topics include family dynamics, social inequality, urbanization, and crime. Anthropology studies humans from both cultural and biological perspectives, often looking at how societies have developed over time. It uses methods like ethnography to understand rituals, kinship, language development, and human origins. Political science is concerned with how societies govern themselves, analyzing political institutions, public policies, and international relations. Topics might include how elections work, the nature of democracy, policy evaluation, and global conflicts. While all three disciplines study aspects of human society, sociology looks at social structures and interactions, anthropology explores cultural diversity and human evolution, and political science focuses on systems of power and governance.

Question 2: Describe the structure and function of a typical social survey. Why are surveys important in social science research?

Answer: A social survey is a systematic way to collect information from people, usually through questionnaires or interviews. Its main parts are: - Sampling: Selecting a group that represents the larger population. - Questionnaire: A set of structured or semi-structured questions. - Data Collection: Gathering answers via interviews, phone calls, online forms, or mail. - Analysis: Looking for trends, relationships, or patterns in the data. Surveys are valuable in social science because they provide quantitative data about people's attitudes, behaviors, and demographics. This helps researchers understand social trends, test theories, and inform public policy.

Question 3: Discuss the ethical considerations and societal impacts of conducting social science research with human participants.

Answer: Ethical issues in social science research include: - Informed Consent: Making sure participants know what the study is about and agree to take part. - Confidentiality: Protecting participants' identities and personal information. - Non-maleficence: Avoiding any harm or distress to those involved. - Right to Withdraw: Allowing participants to leave the study at any time. Research can benefit society by shaping policies and deepening understanding of social issues. However, unethical practices or misuse of data can erode public trust, reinforce stereotypes, or harm vulnerable groups. That's why ethical oversight and clear communication are essential.

Question 4: Explain the concept of social stratification and discuss its advantages and limitations in understanding society.

Answer: Social stratification is the ranking of people or groups in society based on things like wealth, education, power, or status. Advantages: - Explains patterns of inequality and social mobility. - Provides a framework for examining class, gender, race, and other divisions. - Helps us understand how resources and opportunities are distributed. Limitations: - Can oversimplify complex social realities. - May reinforce stereotypes or justify inequalities. - Doesn't always consider individual choices or cultural differences. Researchers continue to refine theories of stratification to better address issues like intersectionality and social change.

Question 5: Describe the principles of qualitative research and how interviews are used to explore social phenomena.

Answer: Qualitative research aims to deeply understand social experiences using non-numerical data. Its principles include: - Focusing on the context of participants' lives. - Using flexible, open-ended ways to gather information. - Emphasizing meaning, interpretation, and the processes behind social actions. Interviews are a key qualitative tool, allowing researchers to explore people's motivations, beliefs, and experiences in detail. They can be structured, semi-structured, or unstructured, and are used to collect rich, descriptive data on topics like identity, social change, and group behavior.